

Avaali's Kannan says that upskilling can dampen the impact of the irrelevance of skills due to the increased usage of automation and AI, irrespective of gender. She adds that policymakers and corporate houses together need to ensure that people's livelihoods are not disrupted by AI.

Another area where the development of these technologies is impacting women more than men, is in how these technologies are being used by people. Recent examples show that deepfakes are being used to target women of prominence. With no control over who can use them, and no norms over what uses these technologies can be put to, deepfakes have become the latest tool being used to target women on online platforms. "Deepfakes are created to target women more than men. Over 90 per cent of the deepfakes around the world are created from a pornographic standpoint. But not for consumers of pornography. They are used to embarrass, demean and destroy the dignity of women in public spaces and society," says Bindra.

Per research from Amsterdam-based cybersecurity firm Sensity (earlier called Deepttrace), over 97 per cent of the pornographic content made using deepfake tech were videos of women. Danielle Citron, a law professor at University of Virginia School of Law and author of *Hate Crimes in Cyberspace*, says, "Deepfake technology is being weaponised against women by inserting their faces into porn. It is terrifying, embarrassing, demeaning and silencing. Deepfake videos say to individuals that their bodies are not their own and can make it difficult to stay online, get or keep a job, and feel safe."

With the recent instances of



"Limited access to funding for female-led start-ups continues to contribute to the under-representation of women in leadership positions"

SRIVIDYA KANNAN, FOUNDER AND DIRECTOR, AVAALI SOLUTIONS



"As AI becomes pervasive, this issue (bias in AI) might grow... Hence, there's a need for transparency around the data on which AI models are trained"

KAVITA GUPTA, FOUNDER AND MANAGING PARTNER, DELTA BLOCKCHAIN FUND



"Not only the government, but even tech and social media firms need to play their part in curbing the menace [of AI-based tech being used to harass women online]"

SRAY AGARWAL, PRINCIPAL CONSULTANT-AI, FRACTAL ANALYTICS

viral deepfake videos, the Indian government has also swung into action. India's IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw had recently said that the government is working on a law to regulate the issue. But Fractal's Agarwal says that not only the government, but even tech and social media firms need to play their part in curbing the menace.

While in the larger scheme of things, technology is proving to be a great leveller of the various inequalities in our society, recent trends in the domain of technology development and deployment

show that the path to equitable representation in tech demands concerted efforts from both industry leaders and policymakers. From combating algorithmic biases to addressing funding disparities, the journey towards gender inclusivity is multifaceted. Hence, as we navigate the complex intersection of technology and diversity, a collective commitment to gender inclusivity is paramount to ensure a future where innovation thrives through the confluence of diverse voices. **BT**

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